

Sweet Pepper Grow Guide

For bell pepper / sweet pepper seedlings, small farms, containers, and home gardens.

Quick Rescue - Quick Numbers - Sunlight/Soil/Water - Feeding - Harvesting - Problems - Transplanting

Crop	Sweet pepper / bell pepper / <i>Capsicum annuum</i>
Main use	Fresh market, cooking, salads, sandwiches, stuffed peppers, seasoning, and home garden harvest.
Important note	Sweet peppers are not hot peppers. Most bell peppers are mild and are harvested green, yellow, orange, red, or other mature colors depending on variety.

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

1. Quick Rescue Page: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Most Likely Cause	What To Do First
Seedling wilts after planting	Transplant shock, hot sun, dry root ball	Shade 1-2 days, water gently, and avoid fertilizer until plant recovers.
Leaves yellow while soil is wet	Overwatering, poor drainage, root stress	Reduce watering, improve drainage, lift pots off wet ground, and avoid soggy soil.
Tiny white insects fly up	Whiteflies	Spray under leaves, use yellow sticky traps, repeat every 3-5 days, and control weeds.
New leaves curled or sticky	Aphids, whiteflies, thrips, or virus	Inspect leaf undersides. Spray pests early. Remove badly distorted growth if needed.
Flowers dropping	Heat stress, water stress, low pollination, excess nitrogen	Water evenly, mulch, reduce heavy nitrogen, and avoid severe drying.
Big green plant but few fruit	Too much nitrogen or not enough sun	Give 6-10 hours sun and switch from leaf-growth feeding to fruiting support.
Dark sunken spot on fruit bottom	Blossom-end rot from calcium movement problem, often uneven water	Keep watering even, mulch, avoid root damage, and do not overuse nitrogen.
Brown/black leaf spots	Bacterial spot, cercospora, anthracnose, or fungal leaf spot	Remove affected leaves, avoid wetting leaves, improve airflow, do not work plants wet.
Plant suddenly collapses	Phytophthora/root rot, bacterial wilt, severe root damage	Remove badly affected plant, improve drainage, avoid planting peppers in the same sick spot.

Send clear photos of the full plant, leaf close-up, underside of leaves, stem base, soil/pot, and fruit damage to WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415.

2. Quick Numbers Page

Item	Specific Range / Target
Botanical name	Capsicum annum
Pepper type	Sweet pepper / bell pepper - mild, non-pungent fruit
Seed germination	7-14 days in warm conditions; can take up to 21 days if cool
Seedling transplant age	6-8 weeks after sowing, once strong and hardened off
Hardening-off period	7-10 days before outdoor/full-sun planting
Sunlight	Minimum 6 hours; best 8-10 hours daily
Best growing temperature	About 21-29 C / 70-85 F for strong growth
Heat stress risk	Above 32 C / 90 F, especially with dry soil and hot nights
Home garden spacing	18-24 inches between plants
Small farmer rows	30-36 inches between rows; 18-24 inches in-row
Container size	Minimum 3 gallons; better 5 gallons or larger per plant
Green mature harvest	About 70-80 days after transplanting for many bell peppers
Color ripe harvest	About 2-3 weeks after mature green stage
Water target	About 1-2 inches per week, adjusted for heat, rain, soil, and container size

Numbers vary by variety, plant size at purchase, sunlight, soil, container size, rainfall, heat, and care.

3. Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Sweet peppers need strong light, warm soil, and steady moisture. Most poor fruiting comes from low sun, root stress, uneven watering, or too much nitrogen.

Need	Target	Customer Notes
Sunlight	6-10 hours daily	Best fruiting usually comes with 8-10 hours. In very hot areas, morning sun plus light afternoon relief can reduce stress.
Soil texture	Loose, fertile, well-draining	Avoid soil that stays waterlogged after rain. Raised beds help in wet areas.
Soil pH	About 6.0-6.8	Compost improves soil structure and root health.
Water	1-2 inches per week	Containers may need water more often. Keep watering even once flowers and fruit appear.
Mulch	2-3 inches thick	Keep mulch slightly away from stem. Mulch reduces heat stress, weeds, and water swings.
Airflow	Leaves should dry quickly	Good spacing lowers leaf spot and mildew pressure.

Do not keep pepper roots constantly wet. Peppers like moisture, but they do not like soggy root zones.

4. Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	Feeding Direction
At planting	Day 0	Mix compost into bed or potting mix. Use a balanced fertilizer lightly if soil is weak.
After settling	10-14 days after transplant	Feed lightly once plant is no longer wilted. Avoid strong fertilizer on stressed seedlings.
Vegetative growth	Weeks 2-5 after transplant	Support steady leaf and root growth, but do not push soft, overly leafy growth.
Flowering begins	Often 4-7 weeks after transplant	Reduce heavy nitrogen. Support phosphorus, potassium, calcium, and consistent watering.
Fruiting stage	Fruit visible	Feed lightly every 2-4 weeks in pots or 3-5 weeks in ground, based on plant color and growth.
Harvesting stage	Ongoing	Keep water consistent and avoid sudden heavy nitrogen that can reduce fruiting balance.

Too much nitrogen can give a large green plant with fewer flowers and fruit. Use compost, balanced feeding, and fruiting support once flowers begin.

5. Harvesting Guide

Harvest Stage	When To Harvest	Notes
Green mature	Fruit is full size, firm, glossy, and deep green	Many bell peppers are ready around 70-80 days after transplanting.
Color ripe	Fruit changes to red, yellow, orange, purple, or other variety color	Usually 2-3 weeks after the green mature stage; flavor is often sweeter.
Market harvest	Fruit firm and clean, before soft spots	Cut with scissors/pruner, leaving a short stem on fruit.
Home harvest	Pick as needed	Regular picking can encourage more fruit set.
Harvest frequency	Every 5-10 days during production	Remove damaged fruit early so pests/diseases do not build up.

Use scissors or a clean pruner. Pulling peppers by hand can break branches.

6. Leaf Color and Plant Problem Guide

Leaf / Plant Look	Possible Cause	What To Do
Medium to deep green leaves	Healthy plant	Continue steady watering, feeding, sunlight, and pest checks.
Very pale leaves	Low nitrogen, low sunlight, or root stress	Improve sunlight, check drainage, add compost, and feed lightly.
Yellow lower leaves	Old leaves, overwatering, low nitrogen	Check soil moisture first. Remove yellow leaves if disease-free.
Purple tint on young plant	Cool stress or phosphorus/root stress	Keep warm, avoid wet roots, feed only after plant settles.
Curled new leaves	Thrips, aphids, whiteflies, mites, virus, herbicide drift	Inspect pests. Separate severely distorted plants if virus is suspected.
Brown leaf edges	Dry soil, heat stress, fertilizer burn	Water evenly, mulch, and reduce strong fertilizer.
Leaf spots with yellow halos	Bacterial or fungal leaf spot	Remove affected leaves, avoid overhead water, improve spacing.
Wilting midday only	Heat stress	Mulch and water early. Plant may recover by evening.
Wilting morning and evening	Root problem or severe disease	Check roots, drainage, and stem base. Remove collapsing plants.

7. Flowering and Fruiting Problems

Problem	Likely Cause	Action
Flowers drop before fruit	Heat above 32 C / 90 F, dry soil, hot nights, low pollination, excess nitrogen	Keep water even, mulch, improve airflow, avoid heavy nitrogen.
Plant flowers but fruit is poor	Stress, poor pollination, pest damage, low potassium	Check pests in flowers, feed lightly for fruiting, and avoid water swings.
Small fruit	Poor nutrition, small pot, irregular water, variety type	Use larger pot, feed lightly, water evenly.
Blossom-end rot	Calcium transport problem often from uneven watering	Keep soil evenly moist, mulch, avoid root damage and too much nitrogen.
Sunscald on fruit	Fruit exposed to intense sun after leaf loss/pruning	Keep enough leaf cover. Avoid heavy pruning. Control leaf diseases.
Misshapen fruit	Poor pollination, thrips, heat stress	Check flowers for thrips and keep plants evenly watered.

Sweet peppers are self-fertile, but stress can still reduce fruit set. Healthy leaves, even water, and enough sunlight are key.

8. Small Farmer Notes

Practice	Recommended Approach
Spacing	Use 18-24 inches in-row and 30-36 inches between rows for airflow and harvest access.
Raised beds	Use raised beds where soil holds water or rain is heavy.
Mulch	Use dry grass, weed mat, plastic mulch, or organic mulch to reduce weeds and water swings.
Staking	Stake or string plants where wind, heavy fruit, or soft soil may cause lodging.
Irrigation	Drip or careful soil-level watering lowers leaf wetness and disease spread.
Crop rotation	Avoid planting peppers after peppers, tomato, eggplant, or Irish potato in the same bed when disease was present.
Record keeping	Track date planted, variety, feed dates, first flowering, first harvest, pest treatment, and yield.

9. Home Garden Notes

Situation	Simple Guidance
2-6 plants	Plant 18-24 inches apart or use one 5-gallon pot per plant.
Balcony/patio	Use 5-gallon or larger pot with drainage holes; full sun is best.
Small yard	Mulch and stake plants to keep fruit clean and branches supported.
Rainy periods	Reduce watering and improve drainage. Watch leaf spots.
Hot sunny areas	Keep soil moist, mulch heavily, and avoid pruning away too many leaves.
Harvest use	Pick green for cooking or wait for full color for sweeter flavor.

For the home gardener, the biggest success factors are pot size, sunlight, drainage, and consistent watering once fruit starts.

10. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Peppers can be affected by plant viruses and leaf diseases that spread by insects, tools, hands, plant sap, and contaminated material. Clean handling lowers risk.

Do This	Why It Matters
Wash hands before handling seedlings	Reduces transfer of plant disease organisms.
Keep cigarettes and tobacco away from seedlings	Tobacco products can be associated with tobacco mosaic virus risk in peppers and tomato.
Do not smoke and then handle seedlings without washing hands	Wash with soap and water before touching peppers.
Clean scissors/pruners before use	Reduces spread of bacteria, fungi, and viruses between plants.
Do not work plants when leaves are wet	Wet leaves spread bacterial and fungal leaf spots more easily.
Remove sick leaves from the garden	Do not leave diseased leaves under plants

Customer warning: wash hands after smoking or handling cigarettes before touching pepper seedlings or plants.

11. Hardening Off Seedlings

Hardening off prepares seedlings from trays or protected areas for stronger sun, wind, and outdoor stress. Do this before final planting when possible.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade or gentle morning light for 2-3 hours. Keep tray moist.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 3-4 hours, then shade. Avoid midday heat.
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus longer outdoor exposure. Protect from heavy rain and strong wind.
Day 7-10	Ready for planting if seedlings stay upright and do not wilt badly.

Do not take tray-grown pepper seedlings straight from shade into full hot sun. Sudden stress can slow growth and delay fruiting.

12. Transplanting from Trays or Small Pots

Step	Instruction
1	Water seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.
2	Prepare holes or pots before removing seedlings from trays.
3	Handle by root ball or leaves, not by crushing the stem.
4	Keep root ball together as much as possible.
5	Plant at the same depth as the tray/pot soil level.
6	Press soil gently around roots; do not pack hard.
7	Water immediately at soil level.
8	Shade lightly for 1-2 days if sun is harsh.
9	Avoid strong fertilizer for the first few days if plant is wilted.
10	Check morning and evening for the first 2-5 days.

Pepper seedlings can suffer transplant shock. Careful handling and steady moisture help them settle faster.

13. Common Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects under leaves, yellowing, sticky residue	Spray under leaves, use yellow sticky traps, control weeds, repeat every 3-5 days.
Aphids	Soft insects on new growth, curling, sticky leaves, ants	Spray with water, use mild soap spray, control ants, repeat every 3-5 days.
Thrips	Silvery/bronze marks, distorted flowers/leaves, poor fruit shape	Remove damaged growth, use sticky traps, spray carefully around new growth/flowers.
Spider mites	Fine speckling, dusty leaves, webbing, worse in hot/dry weather	Spray leaf undersides, reduce drought stress, remove badly damaged leaves.
Pepper weevil	Small holes, fruit drop, larvae inside fruit	Remove fallen/damaged fruit, keep field clean, monitor early.
Cutworms	Young seedlings cut at soil line	Check early morning, use collars/barriers, remove weeds and debris before planting.
Caterpillars/worms	Chewed leaves or fruit, black droppings	Handpick, check evening/early morning, remove damaged fruit.

14. Common Diseases and Disorders

Issue	Signs	First Response
Bacterial spot	Small dark leaf spots, yellow halos, spots on fruit	Avoid wet leaves, improve spacing, remove affected leaves, do not work plants wet.
Anthrachnose	Sunken circular fruit spots, often on ripening fruit	Remove infected fruit, avoid overhead watering, harvest promptly.
Cercospora leaf spot	Circular leaf spots with light centers	Remove bad leaves, improve airflow, reduce leaf wetness.
Phytophthora blight/root rot	Wilting, stem/root rot, collapse in wet soil	Improve drainage, remove infected plants, avoid waterlogged beds.
Tobacco mosaic virus	Mottled/mosaic leaves, stunting, distorted growth	Remove badly infected plants, wash hands, avoid tobacco contamination.
Blossom-end rot	Dark sunken bottom of fruit	Maintain even water, mulch, avoid root injury and over-fertilizing nitrogen.
Sunscald	Pale/tan burned patches on exposed fruit	Maintain healthy leaf cover and reduce excessive pruning.

15. ParaLife Trees Support

Need help with your sweet pepper seedlings? Send clear photos before the plant gets too weak.

Photo To Send	Why
Full plant	Shows overall growth, wilting, color, and shape.
Top leaves	Shows new growth problems and pest damage.
Underside of leaves	Whiteflies, aphids, mites, and eggs often hide there.
Stem base and soil/pot	Helps identify drainage, rot, and transplant problems.
Flower/fruit close-up	Helps diagnose fruit set, blossom-end rot, sunscald, or pest damage.

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

ParaLife Trees - Planting a Life in Paradise

16. Reference Notes

This customer guide was prepared using practical pepper-growing guidance from extension and agriculture sources, then adapted for ParaLife Trees seedlings, small farms, home gardens, pots, and Jamaican growing conditions.

Source	Guidance Used
University of Maryland Extension - Growing Peppers in a Home Garden	Sunlight, spacing, harvest timing, mature green vs ripe color timing, and home garden management.
Virginia Cooperative Extension - Peppers	Pepper spacing, crop type, and common disease list.
University of Minnesota Extension - Growing Peppers	Temperature caution, transplanting after warm nights, and hot weather flower drop.
UC IPM - Peppers	Cultural care, pest/disorder management, and plant health prevention approach.
Oklahoma State University - Pepper Production	Small farm production framing and pest/disease production considerations.

For severe disease or commercial crop losses, seek local agricultural extension support before applying chemical treatments.